Beyond popularity: What makes anime successful?

How anime atmosphere, format, and content characteristics are associated with audience reach, ratings, and loyalty

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Data Visualization Final Project

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Popularity alone does not fully describe anime success

Anime success can be measured in several ways:

- Audience reach – how many users added a title to their list
- User evaluation – the average rating assigned by users
- Audience loyalty – the proportion of members who marked a title as a favorite

How are anime characteristics associated with popularity, user ratings, and audience loyalty, and how have these relationships changed over time?

The project focuses particularly on anime atmosphere,

release format, historical period, studios, and genre–theme combinations.



A multidimensional MyAnimeList - derived dataset enables several definitions of success

Main variables:

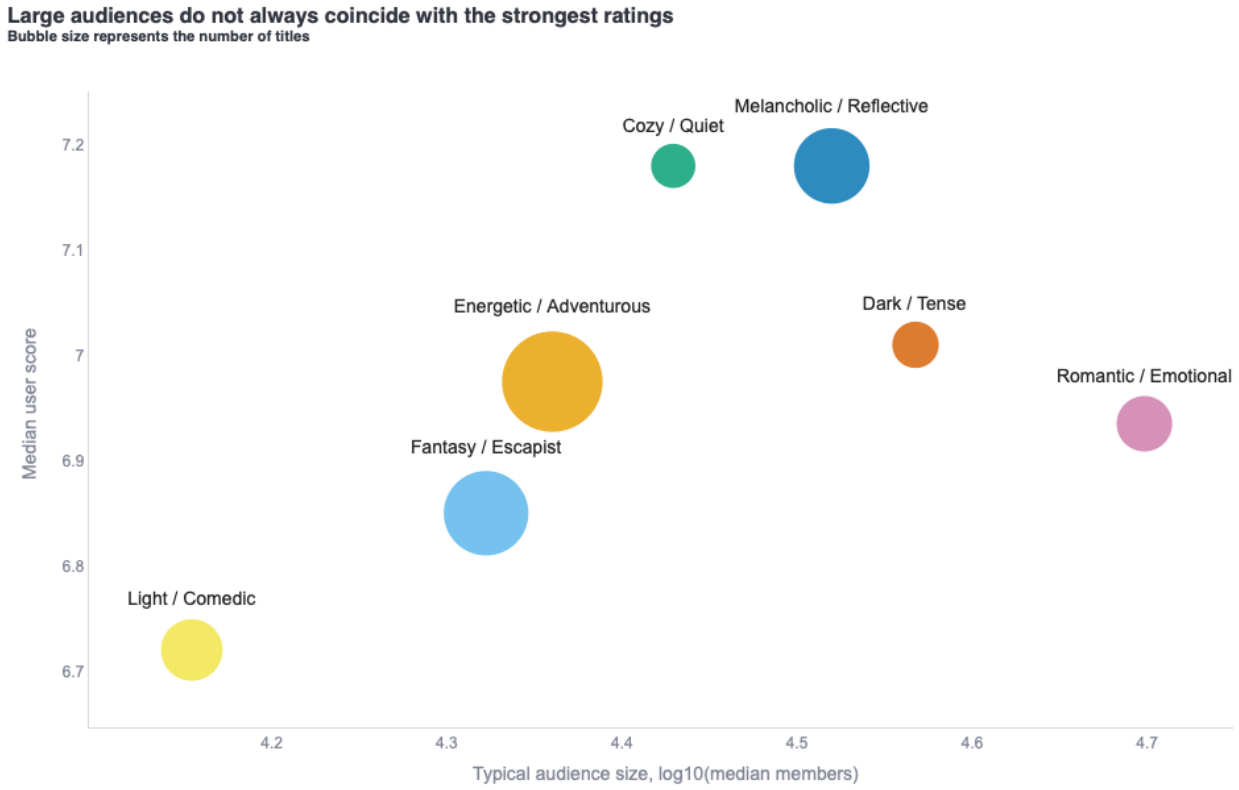
- Title and release format
- Release year
- Score and number of ratings
- Members and favorites
- Genres and themes
- Studios
- Source material

Data preparation:

- Removed or handled missing values
- Restricted rating analyses to sufficiently rated titles
- Used medians for strongly skewed audience data
- Created a rule-based atmosphere classification
- Calculated favourites-to-members loyalty rate
- Compared titles within historical periods

MyAnimeList members represent users who added a title to their list, not necessarily completed viewers.

Large audiences do not always coincide with the strongest user ratings

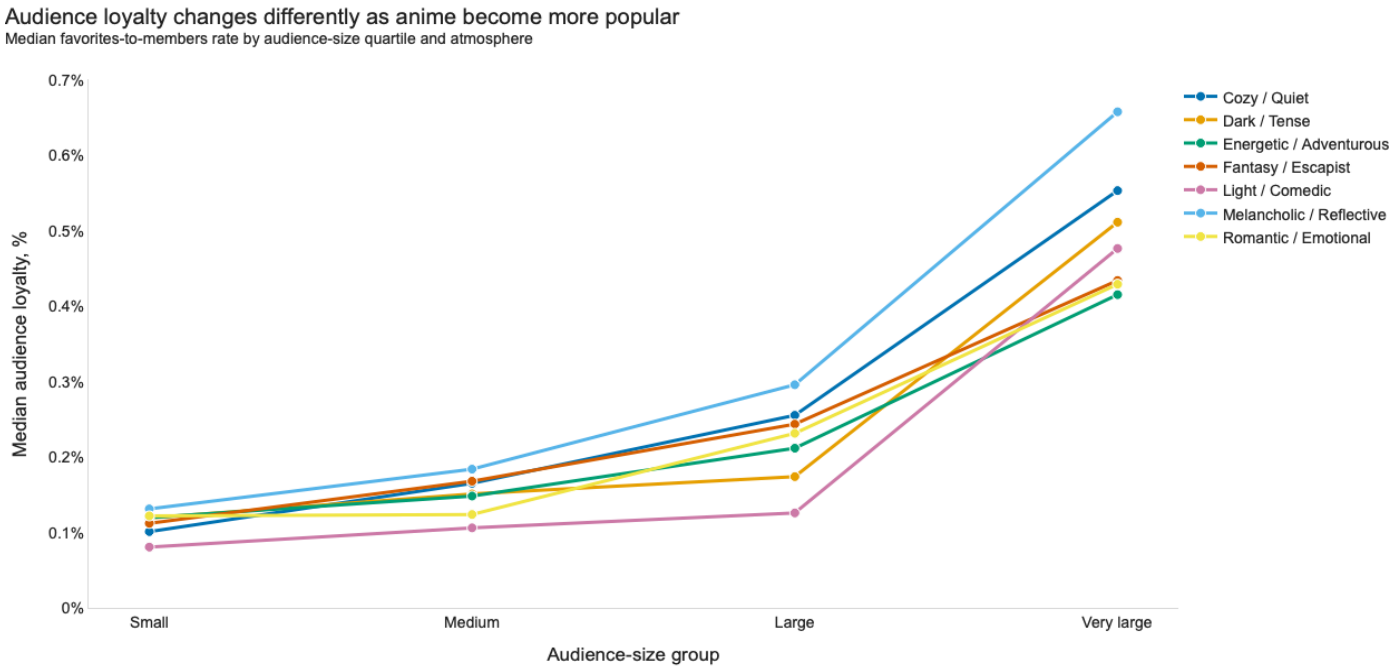


Atmosphere categories occupy different positions in the audience–rating space.

Some atmospheres achieve strong ratings without the largest typical audiences.

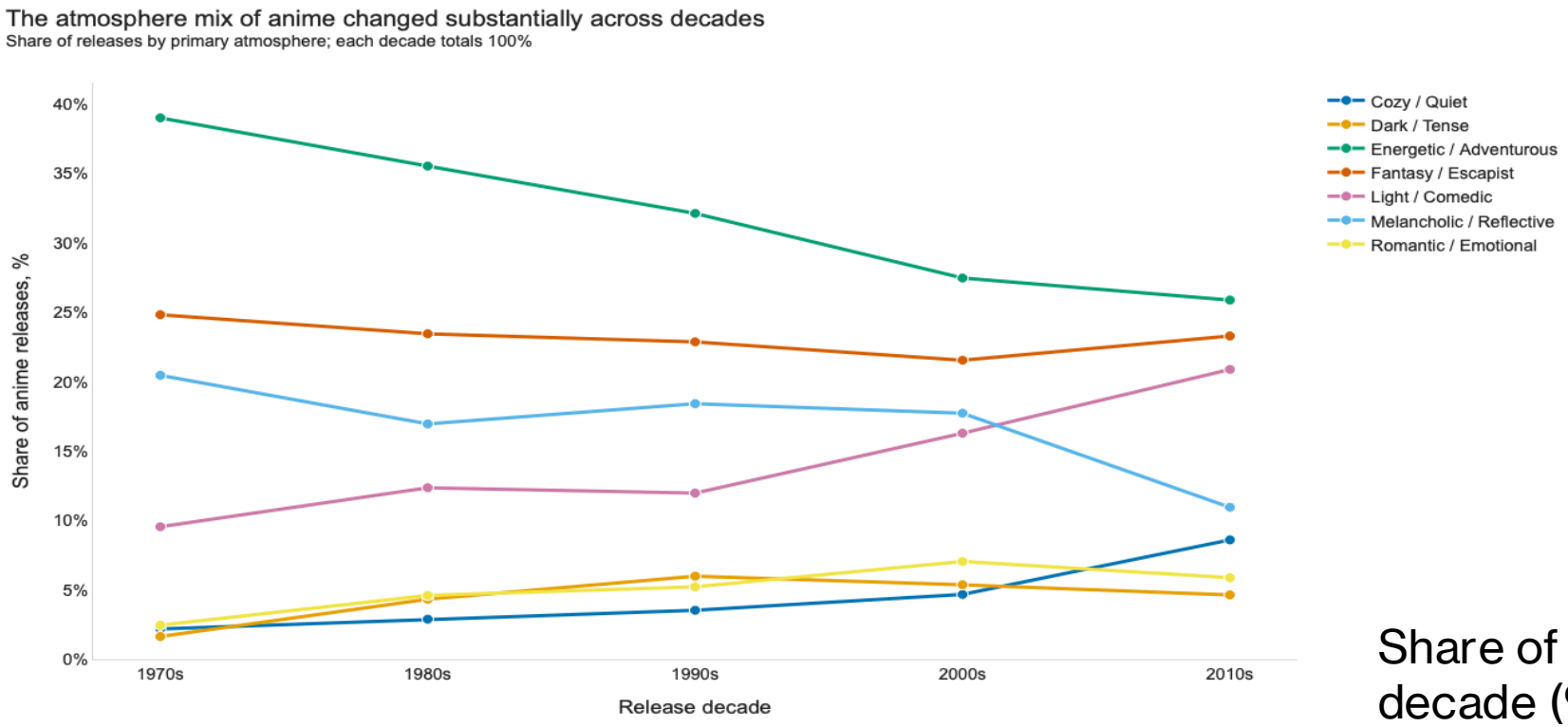
Popularity and user evaluation should therefore be treated as separate dimensions.

Audience size and audience loyalty are related, but they are not the same measure



- A title can reach a large audience without generating an equally strong favourite rate.
- Loyalty provides an additional measure of emotional attachment.
- Atmosphere remains associated with different loyalty patterns even across audience-size groups.

The atmospheric composition of anime changed across decades

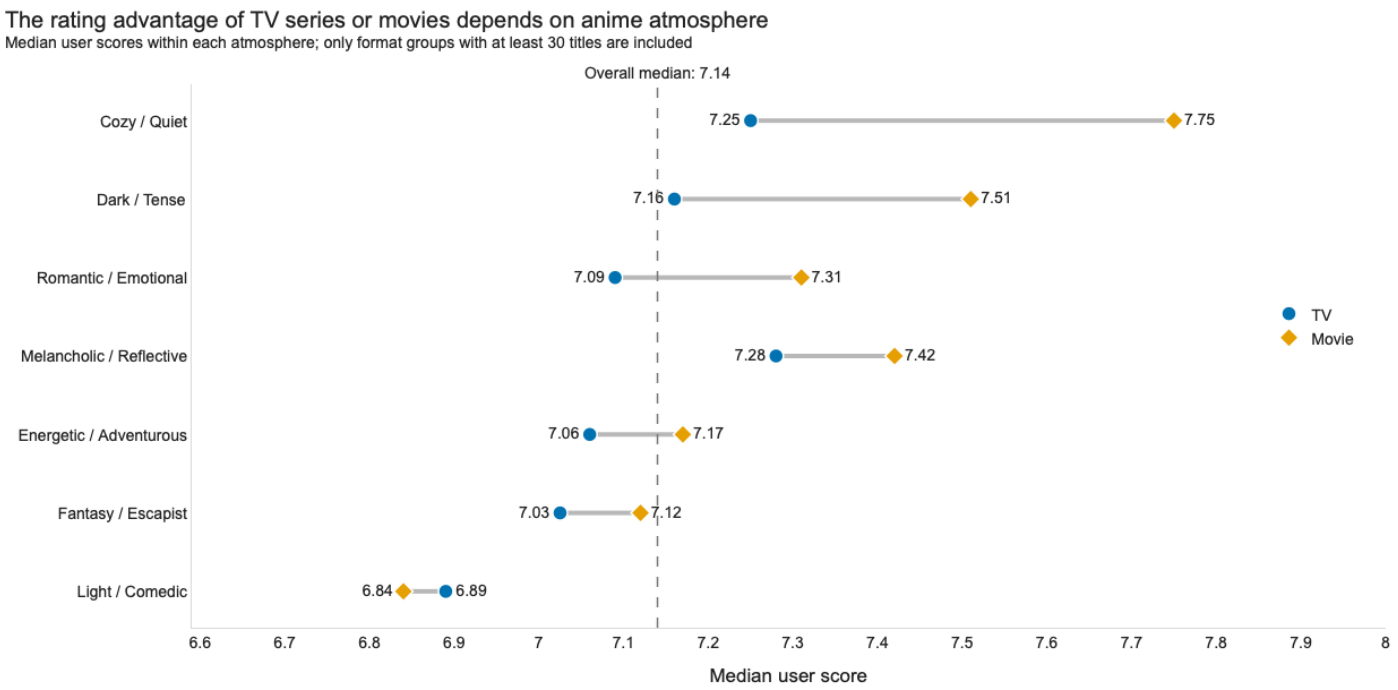


Share of anime titles within each decade (%)

- The anime market did not expand uniformly across all atmosphere categories.
- Some atmosphere profiles became more visible in later decades.
- Historical context is important because newer titles also operate within a much larger market.

Movies usually receive slightly higher ratings, but the difference depends on atmosphere

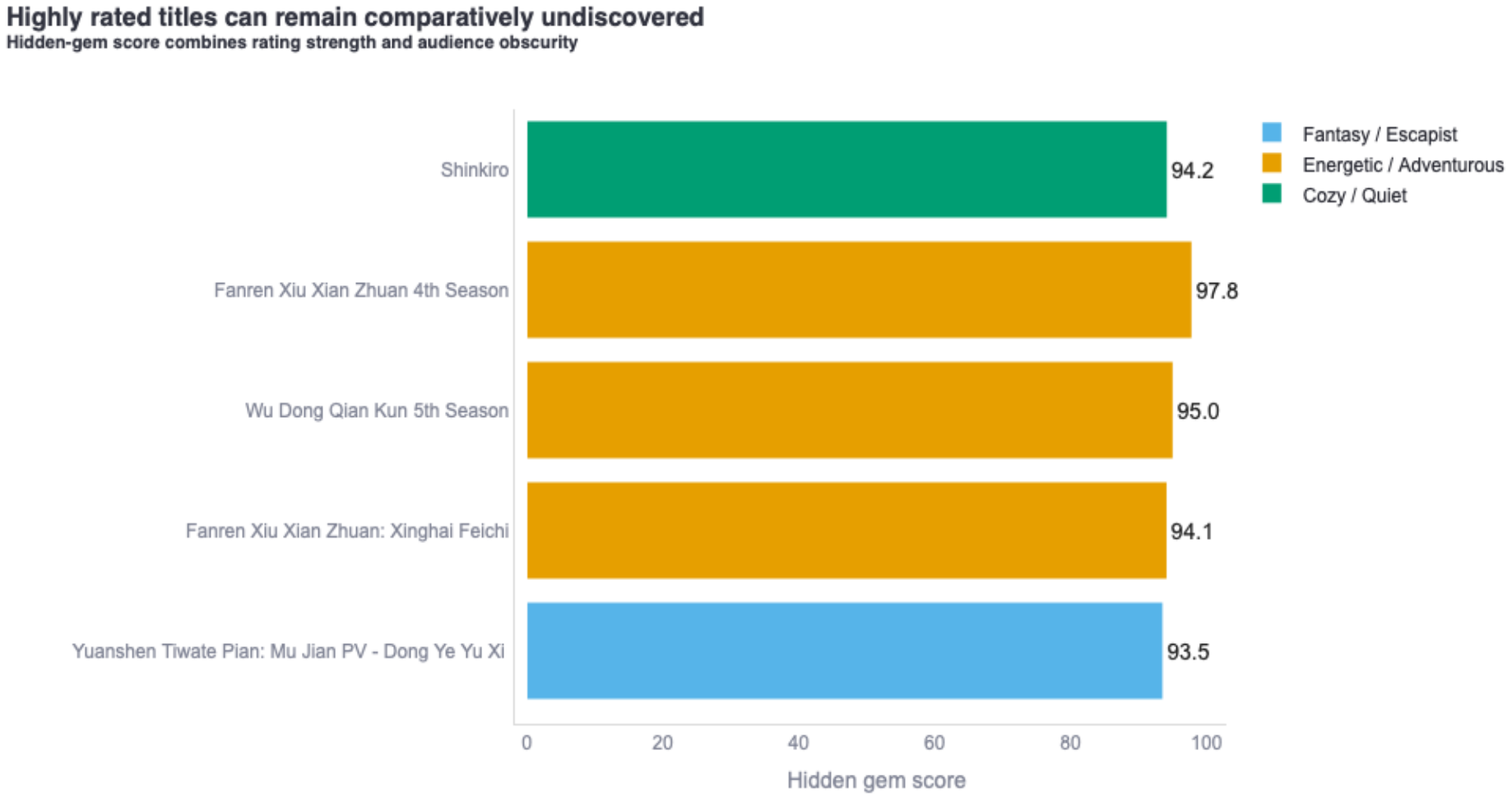
- Format differences are generally modest rather than dramatic.
- The direction and size of the gap vary across atmosphere categories.
- Format therefore interacts with content profile instead of acting as a universal advantage.



Strong ratings do not guarantee broad discovery

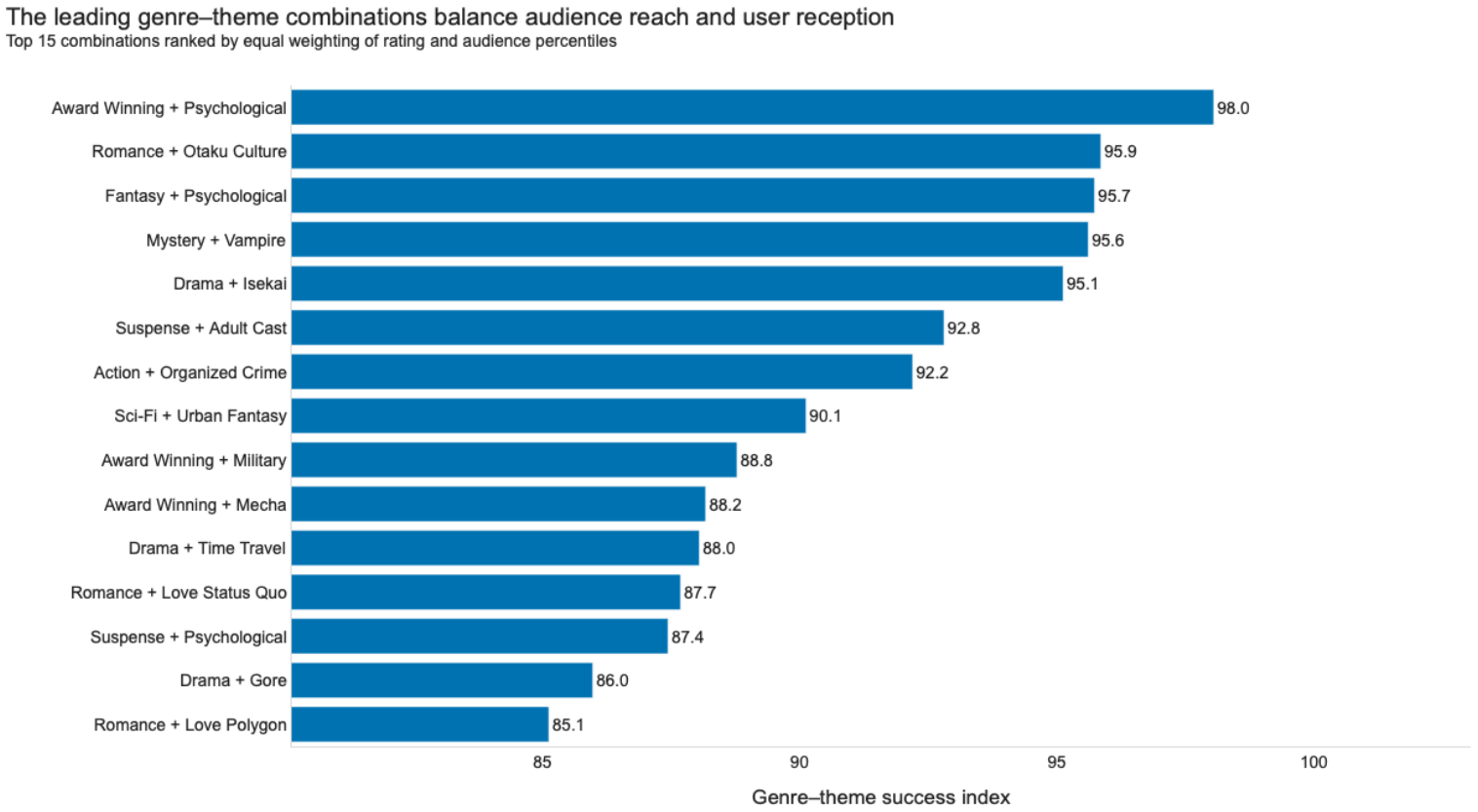
Hidden gems combine:

- high rating percentile
- low audience percentile



Some content combinations balance rating strength and audience reach

Success index = average of rating percentile and audience percentile



Anime success is multidimensional

1. Audience reach, user rating, and loyalty describe different forms of success.

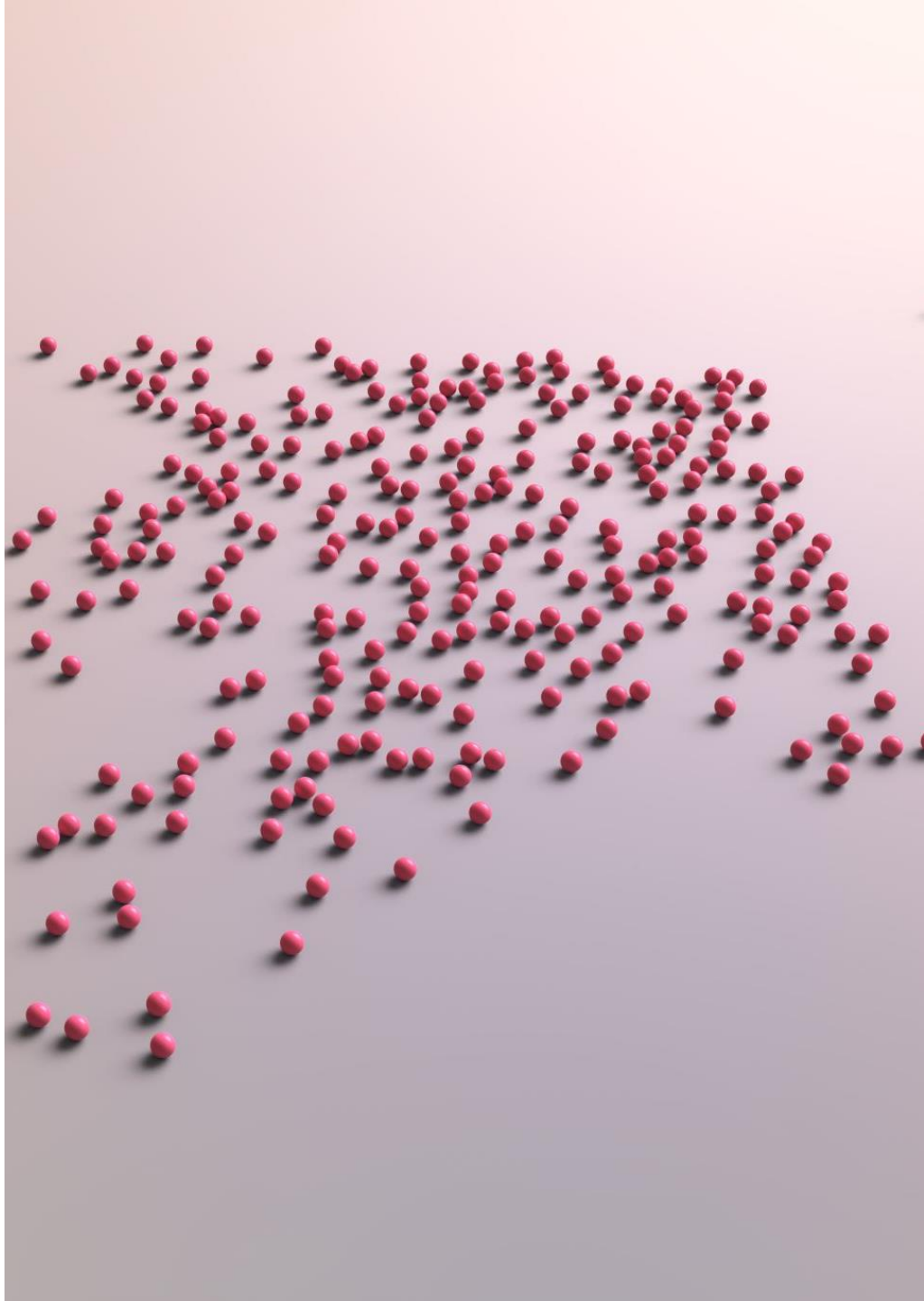
2. Atmosphere is associated with meaningful differences in typical audience size,

ratings, and favourite rates.

3. Historical growth changed both the scale and composition of the anime market.

4. Movies often score slightly higher than TV titles, but the gap varies by atmosphere.

5. Some highly rated titles and content combinations remain comparatively under-discovered.



Limitations

- MyAnimeList users are not the entire global anime audience.
- Members do not equal completed views.
- Atmosphere classification is rule-based and partly subjective.
- Observed relationships are associations, not causal effects.

Links

GitHub repository: https://github.com/Inesmo-Minyard/Data-Visualization-Final-Project.git

Live Streamlit dashboard: https://data-visualization-final-project-y5bsnusnqgmmcgdvp22fvb.streamlit.app/